

TONIGHT'S CARD

DeepSeek Harness (dsh)

Verdict: TRY — with a hard caveat · Dated 19 August 2026 · Killpack.AI

What it is

An open-source agent runtime from DeepSeek. The design principle is that **everything is a plugin**: the model, the tools, the sandbox, the session log, and the agent loop itself are all replaceable.

Set it up and use it, step by step

You don't need to know how to code to follow this. You do need a laptop or desktop — it doesn't run on a phone.

1. Install Node.js (one time, ~2 minutes). Go to nodejs.org, download the version marked "LTS," run the installer, click through it. If you already have Node, skip this.

2. Open your computer's command window. On a Mac: press Cmd+Space, type "Terminal," hit Enter. On Windows: click Start, type "PowerShell," hit Enter. It's a plain black or white text box. It looks intimidating. You're about to type exactly one line into it.

3. Type this and press Enter:

```
npx @deepseek-ai/dsh web
```

Your computer downloads and starts the tool (a minute or two the first time). When it's ready, it prints a web address in that same text box — by default <http://127.0.0.1:3080>.

4. Paste that address into your browser. Chrome, Safari, Edge, whatever you use. You're now looking at DeepSeek Harness running entirely on your own machine, not in the cloud.

5. Give it an AI to think with. Go to platform.deepseek.com, make a free account, and grab an API key (a password that lets this tool borrow DeepSeek's AI). Back in the browser tab from step 4, click

Settings → **Models**, paste the key in, save. It works immediately, no restart needed.

6. Tell it which folder to work in. Click **Choose workspace**, then pick the folder you want it looking at. This is the part that reveals what the tool actually is: it's built to read and edit a folder of code, not to chat about your day. If you don't already have a coding project, this is where a non-coder hits a wall — worth knowing before you start, not after.

7. Give it a job. Click into the message box and type something like:

Summarize this repository and identify its main packages.

Hit send. It reads the folder and answers. If it wants to change a file or run a command, it stops and asks your permission first, every single time. You're never one accidental click from it doing something you

didn't approve.

The honest caveat, same rule this whole card runs on: this is a developer's tool, for people who already write code. If that's not you, you can still poke around it free on your own machine, but the folder you'd point it at in step 6 won't exist yet. That's not a gap in this guide, that's what the tool actually is.

Verified 19 August 2026 straight from the project's own README and official Web UI guide — not a summary of someone else's blog post about it.

The facts I checked

Read from the GitHub API and the repo's own README on 19 August 2026.

Repo	github.com/deepseek-ai/deepseek-harness
Created	13 August 2026
Stars / forks	164,609 / 17,452
License	MIT
Last push	17 August 2026
Status	Developer preview — the README states in capitals that there will be compatibility-breaking changes

The Filter, scored

#	Question	Score	Why
1	Replaces a job, or adds a tab?	2	Replaces a closed agent harness outright
2	Core job in 7 minutes cold?	1	npx install did not finish inside 150s on Windows for me. It's a release candidate.
3	Model named and swappable?	2	The model is a plugin. That's the entire premise.
4	What happens to my data?	2	Runs locally on 127.0.0.1

5	Real cost at a week of use?	2	The harness is free and MIT. You pay only for whatever model you point it at.
6	Would I notice it gone Monday?	2	Yes, if you're building agents
7	Wrapper on a model I already have?	1	It's genuine infrastructure, but early enough that you may end up writing the missing parts
8	Did it match the landing page?	1	Yes, and the page is honest that it's a preview. Docked for the install friction.
	Total	13 / 16	TRY

The one sentence

Take it seriously if you want an agent loop you can actually replace pieces of, but treat it as a preview and keep it away from anything with a deadline.

What most coverage got wrong

Nearly every post about this led with the star count. 164,000 stars in six days is a remarkable number and it tells you **almost nothing** about whether the thing works. Stars measure attention.

The reasons to look at this are the **MIT license** and the **plugin architecture**. The reason to be careful is the **developer preview** warning, which is in the README in capital letters and which almost nobody covering it mentioned.

That gap is the whole reason this card exists.

THE 7-MINUTE PROTOCOL

The process I ran to produce the card above. Run it on anything.

0-1 • Find the primary source. Skip the landing page. Open the repo, the docs, or the pricing page. Get three facts: created date, last push date, license.

1–2 · Check the pulse. Last push over 90 days on a young project is a warning. Over 6 months is usually terminal. High stars with low forks means bookmarking, not usage.

2–3 · Read the license properly. [MIT](#) and [Apache-2.0](#) mean you can use and modify it. [NOASSERTION](#), "source available", or "sustainable use" means strings. A content license like [CC-BY](#) on a code project is a red flag about how the project is run.

3–5 · Run the smallest possible real thing. Not the demo. Your actual job, smallest scale. Can't get there in two minutes? That's your answer.

5–6 · Price the week. Multiply what you just did by your realistic weekly volume. If the pricing page won't let you compute that, it's a 1 at best.

6–7 · Score and write one sentence. The sentence matters more than the number. If you can't write it, you don't understand the tool yet.

Scoring

12–16 TRY · give it one evening, then a 14-day calendar reminder to check if you still use it

8–11 WATCH · don't install, re-check in 60 days

0–7 SKIP · close the tab, don't bookmark it

Question 6 is a veto. If you wouldn't notice it gone on Monday, it's a SKIP regardless of the total.

Want the next one checked? Comment on the video and tell me what tool to look at next, and what job you'd want it to replace. I read every comment.

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